The Beggar

The big idea

Anton Chekhov's story is about **Lushkoff**, a lying, drunken beggar, and **Sergei**, a lawyer who gives him work chopping wood. Lushkoff's life is transformed, but not because of Sergei's charity: the cook **Olga**, who secretly chopped the wood for him, saved him through her **compassion**. The story shows **redemption through kindness**.

Summary

1. A ragged beggar, **Lushkoff**, asks **Sergei** for money, claiming he is a **village schoolmaster** who lost his job through intrigues. Sergei recognises him: earlier, Lushkoff had claimed to be a **student expelled** from college.
2. Caught lying, Sergei threatens to call the **police**. Lushkoff admits his lies and says no one will give him work.
3. Sergei, to test him, offers him work **chopping wood**. Lushkoff agrees, out of pride rather than willingness.
4. Sergei gives him to his cook, **Olga**, who leads him to the woodshed. Sergei watches from the window: Lushkoff seems weak and does little. Still, he gets **half a rouble** for the job.
5. Lushkoff comes back many times; he also shovels snow and cleans up. Later, when Sergei moves house, he sends Lushkoff with a **letter to a friend**, who gives him **copying work**.
6. **Two years later**, Sergei meets Lushkoff at a **theatre ticket window**. He is now a **notary**, earning **thirty-five roubles a month**, and well dressed.
7. Sergei is proud of having saved him. But Lushkoff thanks him and says the real credit goes to **Olga**. Each time, she scolded him for drinking, wept over him,

and **chopped the wood herself**. Her kindness and sacrifice changed his soul and made him give up drinking.

TWIST

Sergei believed his "work instead of charity" plan reformed Lushkoff. In truth, Olga's silent compassion did it.

Characters

- **Lushkoff**: a drunkard and liar at first; capable of change; honest and grateful in the end.
- **Sergei**: a lawyer, well-meaning but self-satisfied and a little proud of his own goodness.
- **Olga**: rough-spoken cook with a kind heart; scolds, pities, weeps and helps.

Themes

- **Kindness and compassion** can redeem a person.
- **Dignity of labour**.
- Good deeds may go unnoticed; humility.

WHO SAVED LUSHKOFF?

Not Sergei, though he helped by giving work and a reference. Lushkoff himself says Olga saved him.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

What two lies did Lushkoff tell? Why did he agree to chop wood? How did Olga help him? How did Lushkoff change? Write a character sketch of Olga.

Quick recap

- Lying beggar Lushkoff is given wood-chopping work by Sergei.
- Olga chops the wood for him and scolds/weeps over him.
- Two years later he is a notary; credits Olga.

Practice questions

1. "The Beggar" was written by
   (a) O. Henry (b) Leo Tolstoy (c) Anton Chekhov (d) Oscar Wilde
2. What was Lushkoff's first false claim to Sergei on the day of the story?
   (a) That he was a village schoolmaster who had lost his job (b) That he was a soldier (c) That he was a farmer whose crops had failed (d) That he was a lawyer
3. What work did Sergei offer Lushkoff?
   (a) Sweeping the street (b) Copying documents (c) Cooking (d) Chopping wood
4. How much did Lushkoff earn for the wood-chopping?
   (a) One rouble (b) Half a rouble (c) Five roubles (d) Thirty-five roubles
5. What was Lushkoff's job when Sergei met him two years later?
   (a) A schoolmaster (b) A cook (c) A notary (d) A lawyer
6. According to Lushkoff, who saved him?
   (a) Sergei (b) Sergei's friend (c) The police (d) Olga, the cook
7. How did Olga help to change Lushkoff?
8. "Kindness can bring about a change of heart that punishment cannot." Discuss with reference to "The Beggar".

Answers: 1. c 2. a 3. d 4. b 5. c 6. d 7. see notes 8. see notes